



STATUS REPORT

Eritrea — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-09-04 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Eritrea [completed its first National Development Plan in 2025](#), and in April 2026 [submitted a domesticated UN Integrated Geospatial Information Framework action plan](#) to UNECA's African Centre for Statistics, intended to improve interoperability between geospatial information and national data systems. A [five-year civil registration and vital statistics plan for 2024 to 2028](#) also stands (July 2026).

Against that, the two policy areas most often taken as markers of a digital agenda are empty. No national broadband plan, strategy or policy has been adopted: the ITU and Broadband Commission's global inventory [recorded none for Eritrea in 2019, as its previous edition had](#), and the only Eritrean instrument that reaches broadband at all is the [2005 National Policy for ICT in Education](#), a sectoral education policy that nothing has superseded. On the Government AI Readiness Index published in January 2026, Eritrea [scores zero for policy capacity](#), a dimension that awards points only for a published national AI strategy, a published draft, or a strategy announced since December 2024.

The planning framework with the most detail in it is jointly authored. The Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework for 2022 to 2026 is [governed by the Ministry of Finance and National Development together with the UN system rather than nationally authored](#), and [commits to an improved and integrated data ecosystem and to digital-technology support across its outcome areas \(2021\)](#) without naming a system delivered against it.

Eritrea's Overall Governance score was [27.5 out of 100 in 2023 and 52nd of 54 African states](#), up [1.9 points over the decade with 1.5 of that gain in the last five years](#), against an African average gain of 0.1.

Legislation and regulation

Eritrea's 2015 Penal Code, which carries the country's [only identified computer-offence provisions](#), [had not entered into force as at March 2025](#), leaving the amended Transitional Penal Code as the operative criminal law.

Two instruments are moving. The Public Procurement and Asset Management laws drafted under the African Development Bank's public financial management project [remained in stakeholder consultation and unenacted in March 2026](#), so the computerised procurement and asset control the project is building still has no statutory basis under it. A [draft Law on National Archives and Libraries](#) has been prepared with expert input from the Research and Documentation Centre and the University of Pavia (November 2025). Eritrea also [acceded to the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities on 20 December 2024](#).

Nothing has been legislated for digital commerce. Neither the UNCITRAL Model Law on Electronic Commerce nor the Model Law on Electronic Signatures has been adopted, so [electronic signatures carry no legal equivalence in Eritrean law](#), and [no consumer-protection provision reaches online commerce](#) (2022). The country is [party to none of the three instruments governing refugee protection](#) and has [no national legal framework for refugees or asylum-seekers](#) (January 2026).

For the financial sector the statute book runs through one instrument: the Eastern and Southern Africa Anti-Money Laundering Group's July 2025 mutual evaluation names [Proclamation No. 175/2014, as amended, as Eritrea's primary financial-sector legislation](#).

Data protection

No comprehensive data-protection law was in force in Eritrea as at August 2026, no supervisory authority had been established and no enforcement decisions had been published. The only provision in point is Article 18 of the 1997 Constitution, a general right to privacy with no implementing statute: [personal data is not defined in Eritrean law](#) and [no body holds a mandate to receive complaints or enforce data-protection obligations](#) (2026).

The gap runs in both directions. [No data-localisation requirement applies to the storage or processing of personal or government data](#) (2026), while personal data is collected at the point of service with nothing around it: [activating a prepaid mobile or fixed line with EriTel requires a copy of the subscriber's national identity card](#) (2025). Such supervision as exists sits with the [Communication Department](#), the only body holding any sector-supervision power over data protection and assessed as [having little to no decision-making authority of its own](#) (2022).

Two external commitments point the other way. Article 15 of the Samoa Agreement [commits Eritrea, as an OACPS party, to building a personal-data-protection regime overseen by an independent supervisory authority](#), and the Horn of Africa Initiative's [target date for Eritrea, Djibouti, South Sudan and Sudan each to hold a national data-protection framework has already been put back once, from December 2025 to December 2026](#).

Complaint machinery is thin more widely: Eritrea has [no independent children's ombudsperson or commissioner mandated to receive and investigate children's complaints](#), and the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child has [recommended one be established in line with the Paris Principles](#) (July 2026).

Regional collaboration

Eritrea is the [only one of the African Union's 55 member states not to have signed the consolidated text of the African Continental Free Trade Area agreement](#), with 49 states having both signed and deposited instruments of ratification (July 2026).

It sits outside the region's digital work as well. Eritrea is [not covered by the Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project](#), the principal live collaboration on harmonised data governance, cybersecurity and cross-border data flows, whose coverage IGAD gives as [Djibouti, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan and Uganda](#) (January 2026). Connecting the country to the region's shared cable infrastructure would require [cross-border regulatory collaboration Eritrea has not undertaken](#) (June 2021), and because Eritrea is [not a party to the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea](#), cable landing rights on its coast rest on a sovereign decision rather than on the treaty framework other coastal states operate under.

The exception is the [Samoa Agreement](#), the EU-OACPS partnership agreement to which Eritrea is a party and which has applied provisionally since 1 January 2024.

Three independent institutional accounts spanning 2020 to 2026 — an IGAD regional infrastructure master plan, a World Bank regional survey and IGAD's live regional digital programme roster — each place Eritrea outside the Horn of Africa's shared digital infrastructure and data-governance tracks.

Standards

The period's substantial standards adoption is operational rather than legal: Eritrea [inaugurated the UNCTAD-built ASYCUDA World customs platform in January 2026](#), replacing a paper-based customs system in place since 2007, with [full source code transferred to the government](#).

Domestic standard-setting still rests on a single statute. [Proclamation No. 75/1995 established the Eritrean Standards Institution as the sole autonomous national body for standardization, quality assurance and metrology](#), combining all three functions in one institution, [empowered it to issue compulsory Eritrean Standards and to certify imports and exports against them](#), and adopted the International System of Units as Eritrea's legal system of measurement.

Inside government the connecting layer is absent: [no interoperability framework and no data quality framework](#) were recorded for Eritrea in 2022, and its payment and wire-transfer security requirements [do not align with international standards such as ISO/IEC or EMV \(2024\)](#). Broadcasting has [no independent regulator](#) (January 2026), and Eritrea has [made no submission to the ITU's telecommunications indicators questionnaire since 2017](#) (March 2026).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Eritrea's deliberative and participatory governance score, which measures whether policymaking involves consultation beyond the executive, [rose 7.4 points over the decade to 14.1 out of 100 in 2023, still 52nd of 54 African states](#).

The broadest consultation of the current period was foreign-funded and sectoral: Eurac Research's NBS4Water project [brought more than 20 stakeholders from the Ministry of Land, Water and Environment, academia, the private sector and NGOs through two rounds of geodesign workshops in July 2026 to co-develop water-security planning scenarios for Asmara](#). [Women's, youth and students' organisations are being consulted on the National Development Plan for 2027 to 2031 \(2025\)](#).

The channels around that are closed. Article 19 of the 1997 Constitution [nominally guarantees access to information, but the operative instrument governing publication is the 1996 Press Proclamation, which requires licensing and pre-approval of all media, and no freedom-of-information law has been adopted](#) (January 2026). Eritrea ranks [last of 180 countries and territories in the 2026 World Press Freedom Index, the third consecutive year in that position, which names the Eritrean journalist Dawit Isaak as jailed without trial for 25 years](#) (May 2026). The country's digital freedom score, measuring government censorship of the internet and online media, was 1.2 out of 100 in 2023, last of 54 African states and down 6.6 points over the decade, and freedom of expression and belief [rose 12.6 points to 12.7 out of 100 over the same period, also last](#).

A UN Commission of Inquiry found in June 2015 that the state [systematically silences anyone who dares to protest, question or express criticisms of the government or its policies, and that surveillance produces self-censorship extending into private and family settings](#). The drafting that does circulate publicly happens outside the country: a diaspora legal-reform project with no standing in any Eritrean institution publishes consultation drafts of Acts, codes, executive regulations and rules intended to reconstruct Eritrea's legal order within the 1997 Constitution.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

Further solar generation at Tesseney, Berantu and Kerkebet, beyond the mini-grid already approved for those towns, was [under discussion at the African Development Bank's mission to Eritrea in April 2026](#). The standing agreement covering United Nations cooperation, the [Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework 2022-2026 signed with the Government of the State of Eritrea](#), is jointly governed by the Ministry of Finance and National Development and the UN system rather than nationally authored.

New investments

The African Development Bank [approved US\\$58.04m for Eritrea's Energy Integrated Project on 18 February 2026](#), made up of a US\$37.31m African Development Fund grant and a US\$20.73m Transition Support Facility grant. The Bank's older engagement is smaller and nearly spent: [UAC 9,000,000 approved on 4 July 2016](#) for the public financial management and statistics technical assistance project, in force from 10 October 2016, stood at 81.65 per cent disbursed at the Bank's supervision mission of 30 November to 30 December 2025. The [United Nations Development Programme has financed national accounts and other macroeconomic statistics work with the National Statistics Office since 2019](#). Outside the digital and data record, the [Global Partnership for Education's US\\$11.82m System Transformation Grant and US\\$2.2m System Capacity Grant, with UNICEF as grant agent](#), are directed at the zobas holding nomadic, semi-nomadic and remote rural communities that lag the national average on education indicators (April 2024).

Eritrea's external development finance for digital and data systems is exceptionally thin (September 2026): three commitments in all, spanning 2016 to 2026, from two financiers — the African Development Bank with two, and the United Nations Development Programme with one. Every one of them is a grant or technical assistance to the public sector; there is no loan, no guarantee, no equity and no commercial or private-sector finance. The subsectors reached are energy, public financial management systems and official statistics, and nothing at all has been committed for connectivity, digital identity, digital payments, data centres or digital skills. Eritrea is also named in none of the 28 regional East African digital commitments on the same record: the East African Community and IGAD-anchored programmes for regional digital integration, AI research, digital skills, cross-border payments and connectivity all run past it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Eritrea has [turned down approaches from submarine-cable operators](#) seeking to land an alternative Red Sea route on its coast, refusing them even at a price as Houthi attacks made Yemeni waters unusable, on a shore the cable industry regards as commercially attractive. The World Bank had already found that the [regional submarine and festoon cable projects planned for the Horn of Africa, and the 2Africa cable, carry no commitment to serve the region as a whole](#), naming Asmara among the places left out (June 2021).

There is [no active internet exchange point in the country](#), so traffic that both begins and ends in Eritrea leaves it over international transit and comes back (2026). The sole operator EriTel [runs 2G technology only, and the ITU records no part of the population covered by a 4G network](#), with coverage concentrated on Asmara and the main urban corridors (2021); the newest international bandwidth figure the ITU holds, [8 kbit/s per internet user](#), is from 2017, the last year Eritrea filed telecommunications data at all.

The internet and computers score reached 23.5 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54 African states and up 22.4 points over a decade, the fastest movement anywhere in Eritrea's infrastructure record, while mobile communications, at 32.6, ranks 51st of 54 from a 2014 base of zero. Fewer than a quarter of the population used the internet in 2023, and an entry-level mobile-broadband basket costs many times what the UN Broadband Commission counts as affordable (2022).

IGAD's regional infrastructure master plan names Eritrea nowhere as a cable landing point, exchange point host or cross-border fibre participant, and treats connections to Sudan or Ethiopia, or to the landing stations at Port Sudan and Djibouti, as short-term work still to be done (March 2020). Inside the country the UNDP scores physical infrastructure at its lowest stage — outdated, limited in coverage and unreliable, with internet resting on satellite and thin terrestrial links (2024), and limited rural electricity and telecommunications keep electronic health data capture above the clinic rather than at it (2024).

Data Storage

The one government data-centre build on the record sits inside the statistical office: African Development Bank financing approved in 2016 equipped the National Statistics Office with its own data centre, and datasets have since been migrated onto modern servers there.

The other place government data sits on infrastructure of its own is customs, where all stations are interconnected over a secure internal intranet so that data can be exchanged and processed without continuous internet access (January 2026) — a design built around unreliable national connectivity rather than evidence of it improving. Between the two there is nothing: Eritrea operates no government service bus, the shared middleware through which public bodies would route data to one another (2022), and it imposes no data localisation requirements on the storage or processing of personal or government data (2026).

Energy

Eritrea's interconnected grid has an installed capacity of 157 MW, of which only 52 MW is reliably available against demand of 74.3 MW (February 2026). Generation depends almost entirely on imported diesel, with renewable sources contributing 6 MW, and generation and distribution assets are ageing and breakdown-prone, with operations constrained by shortages of spare parts. Mining companies run 60 MW of captive generation of their own, outside the national grid.

Captive generation held by the mining companies is of the same order as the reliably available capacity of the entire national grid.

54.4% of the population had access to electricity in 2023, and access to energy is Eritrea's strongest infrastructure showing, 30.5 out of 100 and 32nd of 54 African states in 2023; supply remains concentrated in the major cities (2024). 11.4% of electricity generation came from renewable sources in 2023, against the 2018 National Energy Policy target of 20% renewable supply by 2030, on a solar resource of 2,275-2,314 kWh/m² a year at Tesseney, Kerkebet and Barentu.

The Energy Integrated Project approved in February 2026 will build a 34 MW solar-powered mini-grid with battery storage and 542 km of distribution lines serving Tesseney, Berantu and Kerkebet, expected to benefit around 306,000 people, and is financed under the Bank's Desert to Power initiative and the Mission 300 partnership with the World Bank rather than as a standalone borrowing. It is the third African Development Bank energy intervention in the country, after a 30 MW plant at Dekemhare and a 12 MW mini-grid programme at the same three towns, and the Dekemhare solar plant is operational and supplying the national grid (April 2026).

The power estate now sits in front of the digital one: [government-wide rollout of the financial management system is stated by its financier to depend on reliable power, IT infrastructure and connectivity upgrades \(March 2026\)](#).

Technical Capacity

Eritrea's customs digitisation came with [full transfer of the ASYCUDA World source code to the government and a ten-month capacity-building programme for 100 customs officers, IT specialists and private-sector clearing agents \(January 2026\)](#), the largest single transfer of a working technical capability on the record. It sits against a UNDP assessment that scores [implementation capacity and systems at their lowest stage: an analogue position with no skills, no outsourcing, no strategy and no budget \(2024\)](#).

What capability exists has been built survey by survey and ministry by ministry. [Computer-assisted personal interviewing replaced paper collection for the Fourth Round Population and Health Survey, the first national round the statistics office has run on digital instruments \(May 2026\)](#), and a four-week UNECA workshop trained staff of the Ministry of Land, Water and Environment in GIS and remote sensing in Asmara (February 2026). The Ministry of Education rates [its own teacher management system weak, and its technological infrastructure and connectivity inadequate \(June 2025\)](#), and its education management information system remains largely paper-based and manual (April 2024).

The constraint named most often is people rather than equipment. Capacity to run the national identity system is [severely constrained by the exodus of qualified personnel, limited infrastructure and restricted connectivity \(2018\)](#), and [technical and ICT capacity for civil registration is inadequate at both national and regional level \(2022\)](#). The tertiary pipeline runs through [the Eritrea Institute of Technology at Mai-Nefhi, which carries the country's computer science and related engineering programmes \(2025\)](#). Eritrea sits [near the bottom of the UN e-government ranking, with no online services scored at all \(2024\)](#).

Cybersecurity

Eritrea scored [2.21 out of 100 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index in 2024](#), among the lowest results anywhere, across the index's legal, technical, organisational, capacity-development and cooperation measures. No [national cybersecurity strategy has been published \(2024\)](#).

The only computer-offence provisions identified in Eritrean law are [Articles 374 and 375 of the 2015 Penal Code, covering unauthorised use of a computer and its aggravated form](#). Eritrea is also outside the Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, the region's principal live collaboration on harmonised data governance, cybersecurity and cross-border data flows (January 2026).

The President has said that [secure platforms and a data-protection architecture must be established before detailed personal data is collected for a planned diaspora database \(January 2026\)](#).

DPI

Data Exchange

The only working data exchange Eritrea has built went live in January 2026 and reaches nothing beyond the border posts: [all of the country's customs stations are interconnected over a secure internal intranet](#), so declarations move between them without depending on continuous internet access, while the platform itself [operates as a standalone intranet with no connection to any cross-government exchange](#). It is an operational interoperability arrangement with no statute standing behind it.

Nothing else in government exchanges anything. The UN Development Programme's Digital Development Compass placed Eritrea's data exchange at its lowest stage in 2024, [describing government data handling as offline and paper-based with no systems in place](#). There is [no government interoperability framework](#) and [no data quality framework](#) and [no government service bus](#), the middleware through which public bodies would route data to one another; as at 2022 [none of the financial management, human-resource, payroll, customs, tax or social-insurance systems exchanged data with any other government system](#), and [no strategy, roadmap or legislation governing cross-government data sharing had been adopted](#). The Horn of Africa Initiative placed Eritrea's cross-border and interoperable government data-flow policy at the [nascent stage in June 2025](#), with [no legislation and no regulatory oversight enabling it](#).

Where data does cross an institutional boundary it crosses on paper. [Civil registration and vital statistics data passed between the health sector and the civil registration authority in paper form as at March 2021](#), and there is [no national unique patient identifier](#), [patient-level health systems being unlinked to the aggregated routine health information system](#). An identity-card application requires a birth certificate, but [no automated exchange links the civil registration authority to the Department of Immigration and Nationality](#), so the dependency is worked by hand.

The one recent move sits at the policy layer and is geospatial: Eritrea [submitted a domesticated UN Integrated Geospatial Information Framework action plan to UNECA's African Centre for Statistics on 6 April 2026](#), intended to improve integration between geospatial information and national data systems.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A decade after the electronic card was introduced, [most Eritreans still held the older hand-written identity card in November 2025](#), with a long backlog of applications behind the newer one. The plastic, holographic, fingerprinted card has been issued to citizens aged over 18 by the Department of Immigration and Nationality since late 2015; it carries a laser-engraved photograph, one fingerprint and a unique serial number, but sits behind [no unique digital identifier and no online authentication infrastructure](#).

Nor is there a single file behind it. Each of the six zoba registers [records a per-resident identification number alongside biographic and civil-status fields](#), and residence and family cards are printed as extracts of that zoba's register rather than issued from a national one, fed by birth registration passed up from the Kebabi family register through Nus-Zoba to Zoba level. Running the system is constrained by the exodus of qualified personnel, limited infrastructure and restricted connectivity, though it is administered entirely in-country.

The legal basis is thirty-four years old and silent on all of this: [Proclamation No. 21/1992](#) remains the operative instrument for issuance and addresses neither [digital identity](#), [biometric data](#) nor [data protection](#), and [no dedicated digital identity legislation has been enacted since](#). What does impose identity duties is anti-money-laundering law: [Proclamation No. 175/2014](#) requires every financial institution to establish customer identification and due-diligence policies covering every account and transaction, with the Bank of Eritrea as supervisory authority under Article 5.

The card is the primary legal proof of identity and citizenship and is [required of everyone aged 18 and above](#), being [needed to obtain a passport and to reach government services](#); the UK passport authority confirmed in March 2026 that it remains a precondition of passport issue. It is also the gate to a telephone line: EriTel requires a copy of the national identity card, or a passport for foreign residents, before activating prepaid mobile or fixed-line service, with [no biometric capture in the process](#). It is not free — [about 100 nakfa domestically](#), and [non-refundable dollar fees for diaspora applicants](#) — and for refugees and asylum-seekers in the country, [limited access to documentation heightens the risk of statelessness as at January 2026](#).

Digital Payments and Fintech

Eritrea had no automatic teller machines, no debit or credit cards and no internet banking when anti-money-laundering assessors visited in July and August 2024, and by July 2025 the same evaluation recorded no specific electronic-money or mobile-money regulations, because neither product operates in the country.

The state operator marks the ceiling of what exists. EriTel transfers airtime credit between mobile numbers through a short code at 2 nakfa a transfer and takes bill payments only in cash or cheque at its own pay stations, running no wallet that moves monetary value between people as at 2025. Eritrea is absent from the 31 instant payment systems live across 26 African countries in June 2024, with no G2P-capable digital rail identified there, and it is not a participant in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, directly or through its extended network, remittances still arriving through cash-pickup services such as Western Union as at June 2026; cross-border digital payment functionality is essentially absent beyond correspondent banking and remittance channels. The Digital Development Compass scored payments at its lowest stage in 2024, cash and cheques dominating and digital payments rare, with none integrated into a government service.

None of this is prohibited. Electronic payments, credit cards and internet banking are not legally restricted, even though none of them is offered. The financial system is instead owned and controlled by the State and offers what the evaluators call simple and less sophisticated services, and what the statute book does say constrains in other directions: Proclamations No. 32/1993 and No. 173/2013 require all transactions in Eritrea to be conducted in local currency, which UNECA reads as discriminating against foreign firms seeking to settle payments locally. There is no law addressing consumer protection for digital payment services — disclosure, liability for unauthorised transactions, dispute resolution — and payment and wire-transfer security requirements do not align with standards such as ISO/IEC or EMV, and no independent external audit of payment infrastructure is conducted or published. The African Development Bank named an underdeveloped financial sector among the structural weaknesses limiting economic diversification in November 2025.

Registries

Eritrea's national vital statistics are still derived from Demographic and Health Surveys carried out in 1995, 2002 and 2010 rather than from routine registration, the country having no functional and complete civil registration and vital statistics system as at 2025. Civil registration is also the country's most deteriorated governance indicator of the past decade, down 37.5 points over 2014-2023 to 12.5 out of 100 and 53rd of 54 African states in 2023.

The population register is six registers. There is no central national file: six separate zoba-level digital population registers have run since 2001, each maintained independently of the others and used to issue residence and family cards, an arrangement unchanged as at December 2023. Beneath it, many civil status records are kept in book form and only some Nus-Zoba offices enter them into the digital register, registration forms differ across regions, making records very difficult to collate into one national database, and rural Eritrea has no civil status officers at all, so births, deaths and marriages outside the towns are recorded — where they are recorded — through informal manual declarations. A birth must in law be registered within 90 days for a birth certificate to issue, that certificate underpinning the identity card and passport chain. A five-year Strategic Civil Registration and Vital Statistics Plan for 2024-2028 was recorded by the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child in July 2026, and the UN Committee on the Rights of the Child pressed Eritrea in January 2025 to accelerate digitisation of the civil registry through a computer database still at the planning stage.

The economic registers are statutory and manual. All land vests in the State, and the Cadastral Office under the Ministry of Land, Water and Environment is the sole national land register, created by Proclamation No. 95/1997; it was converting its manual registration system to a digital one in 2020 but had not digitised the spatial component, leaving spatial and textual data unintegrated. The Business Information Register Proclamation No. 124/2002 obliges

the Ministry of Trade and Industry to maintain a national business register and businesses to report to it annually by 15 January, on pain of licence suspension, while business registration and tax registration remain separate manual steps with no system integration. No active electoral register exists: no national election has been held since the 1993 independence referendum, and the Electoral Law's requirement that voters present an identification card is not operative. None of these registers connects to a national data exchange.

Sectoral management information systems

Eritrea's Integrated Financial Management Information System — seven modules covering budgeting, procurement, payroll, cash management, accounting, asset control and reporting — completed pilot rollout and user acceptance testing at the Ministries of Finance, Education and Agriculture, generating reconciled reports by the end of November 2025 and being declared ready for go-live. The same project has the country reporting public debt automatically each quarter and each year on the DMFAS platform since 2019.

At the revenue end, the Inland Revenue Department's tax-administration system was procured in 2023 with African Development Bank support and remains in implementation, while taxpayer identification number registration stays an entirely manual, in-person process at departmental offices. The Bank rated implementation satisfactory in June 2026, with licences, hardware and installation complete and the Release 1 requirements specification finished. Eritrea's tax and revenue mobilisation score nonetheless fell 22.2 points over 2014-2023 to 29.2 out of 100, 48th of 54 African states.

Health has the most developed system and the least reach into the field. The Ministry of Health runs a National Health Information System with HMIS, ICT and system development units at national and zoba level, collecting through paper and electronic channels including DHIS2, which had reached only about 40% of facilities at secondary level and above when the 2022-2026 sector plan was drafted in 2021. Rural facilities record patient data on paper at the point of care, aggregates being keyed into DHIS2 later at zone or sub-zone level, and a tracker module meant to carry patient-level data has been introduced but is not in routine use in rural clinics as at 2024. The 2025 Joint External Evaluation scored early-warning surveillance at 3 out of 5 and pressed for a digitised, USSD-based national electronic disease-reporting system spanning health and agriculture.

Education runs an annual paper census under a digital name. The Education Management Information System was used to diagnose the barriers behind the 2023-2027 Partnership Compact but is largely paper-based and manual, held back by connectivity, equipment, staffing and analytical capacity as at April 2024, even as the ministry publishes annual EMIS reports in hard copy and electronic form. A Teacher Management Information System was named in the Compact as a planned enabling instrument and was not in place; the ministry rated its own teacher information system weak in June 2025.

Across sectors the systems stand apart: the social insurance and pension system run by the National Insurance Corporation of Eritrea neither exchanges data with other government systems nor uses the national identity number to identify beneficiaries.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Eritrea scored 0.1576 on the UN's E-Government Development Index in 2024, 190th of 193 countries and in the survey's low group, with an Online Services Index score of 0.0000, the survey registering no measurable central-government online service provision.

The exception is recent and sits in one agency. Eritrea inaugurated ASYCUDA World, the UNCTAD-built customs platform used in more than 100 countries, on 8 January 2026, replacing a paper-based customs system in place since 2007, and the implementation transferred full source code for the platform to the government.

Nothing comparable faces the public. There is [no government web portal or mobile application for online tax filing and payment](#), the system being procured for the tax administration being a back-office one rather than a taxpayer service as at 2023, and [digital payments are integrated with no government service at all](#). The commitment to change that is external: under [Article 13 of the Samoa Agreement](#), which binds Eritrea, the parties undertake to accelerate the deployment of e-governance and digital public services and to digitalise public registries.

The administrative base underneath is where the movement, such as it is, has been. Eritrea's [effective administration score rose 7.7 points over 2014-2023 to 32.7 out of 100](#), 46th of 54 African states, while public administration as a whole – civil registration, statistical capacity, administrative effectiveness, tax and budget management – fell 7.3 points to 26.8 out of 100 and 49th of 54, the sub-category holding the country's overall governance back the hardest.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

No Eritrean government digital system reaches below the national level: [digital access is concentrated in the towns and at national level, with no sub-national participation in any government system \(2024\)](#).

What does happen at regional level is training. [The government's own account of a geographic information systems course held in Gash Barka in July 2026](#) puts it as addressing gaps in the region's existing information system and improving its documentation practices. An earlier course in Anseba, run by the regional administration with the national Research and Documentation Center, [covered document organisation, preservation, evaluation and digital document management \(September 2025\)](#).

Two such events are on the record between September 2025 and July 2026, in two of the country's six regions.

Computing at that level was last inventoried in 2002, when [the Ministry of Education ran a local area network and internet server at its Asmara headquarters while 30 of 55 sub-zoba offices were reachable only by dial-up modem and 25 held no computer at all](#). The same assessment found [no systematic ICT-management plan governing the ministry's regional and sub-regional offices](#).

Rural digital data capture

Digital access in Eritrea reaches the towns and the national level and stops there: [physical infrastructure sits at the lowest stage of the UNDP's Digital Development Compass, outdated in coverage and unreliable in service \(2024\)](#).

Capture in the countryside is therefore manual, and digitisation begins only after the record has left the village: [rural health facilities write patient data on paper at the point of care, and aggregate figures are entered into the national DHIS2 platform afterwards at zone or sub-zone level \(2024\)](#), and schooling runs on the Ministry of Education's own largely paper-based and manual education management information system (April 2024).

Civil registration has the same shape. [Rural Eritrea has no civil status officers, so births, deaths and marriages outside the towns are declared informally rather than recorded at a registry office \(2025\)](#), which leaves the zoba-level population registers holding only what reaches them. The UN Committee on the Rights of the Child [urged the government to accelerate the planned computerised civil registry and to strengthen the ICT behind birth registration in rural and remote areas \(January 2025\)](#).

The constraints behind that are physical. [Limited rural electricity and telecommunications keep electronic capture above the clinic rather than at it \(2024\)](#), and there is [no commercial 4G network in the country at all \(2021\)](#).

Remedies are aimed at the same places. Eritrea's education reform programme names the zobas holding nomadic, semi-nomadic and remote rural communities as the coverage gap it is meant to close (April 2024), and a digitised national electronic disease-reporting system spanning health and agriculture was still a recommendation when the country was evaluated in August 2025.

Against all of that, rural economy is the single largest driver of Eritrea's decade of governance improvement, rising 18.1 points over 2014-2023 to 32.9 out of 100 in 2023, 42nd of 54 African states.

Technology

AI

The most visible use of AI touching Eritrea in 2026 was against it and about it: a wave of AI-generated images and video [falsely showing Ethiopian forces occupying Assab and Eritrea's president fleeing](#) circulated through the war narrative, made with consumer tools and pushed by pro-Ethiopian and pro-Eritrean accounts alike (April 2026).

The state's own position on paper is empty. Eritrea [has no published national AI strategy, no published draft and nothing announced since December 2024](#), and on the same assessment it scores zero for policy capacity and ranks [193rd of the 195 states covered](#) (2025 edition). An [Artificial Intelligence Institute has been established](#) to promote research and national AI infrastructure (2025).

ICT Industry

Technical training for the sector runs through a private institute rather than a public one: [Polytech, with three branches in Asmara and one in Massawa, teaches computer technology, electrical and electronic technology and audio-visual technology](#) (July 2026). Industry supplies its own power on the same pattern, with [mining companies running 60 MW of captive generation outside the national grid](#) (February 2026).

Every external commitment on Eritrea's digital record is a grant or technical assistance to the public sector: there is no loan, no guarantee, no equity and no commercial or private-sector finance at all (September 2026).

Innovation ecosystem

A state innovation hub has been running since 2023: [the Youth Innovation and Entrepreneurship Hub, under the National Union of Eritrean Youth and Students, gives programming, robotics and electronics training to secondary-school students and holds an annual National Science and Innovation Fair, alongside EriMT, a private co-working and incubation space in Asmara](#) (2025). [AI-generated displays appeared among the innovation exhibits at the National Festival in Asmara](#) (July 2026).

Around that activity the commercial layer is thin, with the [startup base still nascent](#) (2026), and Eritrea sits outside the main international measure of it: it is [not among the 133 economies ranked in the WIPO Global Innovation Index, the underlying data required for inclusion not being available](#) (2024 edition). The [statutory research mandate over information science and technology sits with ESTDA](#) under its founding proclamation.

Capacity

Literacy

Eritrea [scored zero out of 100 for education quality](#) in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states, having fallen 16.7 points over the decade to 2023 — one of the ten most deteriorated of the 96 indicators the Ibrahim Index tracks for the country. Staffing is not what is failing: the same index places [human resources in education among Eritrea's ten best scores](#), at 80.9 out of 100 in 2023, 29th in Africa and up 4.7 points over the same decade.

What sits between the two is enrolment. Education enrolment stood at 27.0 out of 100 in 2023, 44th of 54, and the education sub-category as a whole at 38.7, 43rd, down 4.1 points over 2014-2023 – one of the components pulling against the country's improvement on the index overall. Against that, a laptop programme for high-school students was launched in 2019, and the instrument behind ICT in schools remains a National Policy for ICT in Education dating from 2005, with nothing later replacing it.

Training and skills

Mai-Nefhi College of Engineering and Technology conferred qualifications on 297 graduates on 18 July 2026, 289 first degrees and eight diplomas, a quarter of them women, the list including degrees in computer science and engineering and diplomas in computer application technology and in computer hardware and networking technology. The college is the successor to the Eritrea Institute of Technology, established at Mai-Nefhi in 2004 and restructured into autonomous colleges in 2018, which by its 2019 commencement was offering a computer engineering degree and diplomas in computer, communication and electrical and electronics technology, with a computer application diploma through its College of Science.

The larger recent additions to state skill are external, short and tied to single systems. A ten-month programme accompanying the customs digitisation trained 100 customs officers, IT specialists and private-sector clearing agents (January 2026). UNECA's African Centre for Statistics trained more than 25 Ministry of Land, Water and Environment staff over four weeks in Asmara in remote sensing, satellite land-use and land-cover classification and watershed analysis using ArcGIS Pro and QGIS, closing on 27 February 2026, as the second phase of a multi-year partnership with that ministry. Government employees across the Gash Barka regional administration and its sector branches completed a course in geographic information systems in July 2026.

What is trained is the equipment rather than the record. Instruction given to new recruits and serving police officers covers general computer maintenance and networking, and not any electronic records or case-management system (November 2025).

Outside the university there are two other channels. A three-month vocational programme for college students at Sawa, run through the National Union of Eritrean Youth and Students, carried computer technology among its trades (June 2026), and Polytech, a private technical institute with sites in Asmara and Massawa, added introductory artificial-intelligence courses in 2026. The state technical and vocational system itself grew from two schools with roughly 350 students in 1991/92 to six with 4,640 in 2010/11.

Research institutions

Eritrea's National Health Laboratory has built genomic-sequencing capacity since 2024 with WHO support, training 15 professionals – 13 from the Ministry of Health and two from the Ministry of Agriculture – and applying it nationally for the first time to malaria and antimicrobial-resistance surveillance, producing resistance-pattern data not previously available at national level (July 2026).

The other substantial build is in cultural heritage. The Research and Documentation Centre has been equipped through three successive EU-funded projects, with Italy's University of Pavia as technical partner, to digitise and preserve historic archives, manuscripts and audiovisual material (November 2025), and a draft Law on National Archives and Libraries has been prepared with expert input from the centre and the university.

The statutory architecture is older and sits elsewhere. Proclamation No. 122/2002 established a National Science and Technology Council chaired by the President, the Eritrean Science and Technology Development Agency and a National Science and Technology Advisory Board, gave the agency's research office an explicit mandate over information science and technology alongside eight other domains, and empowered it to found research institutions,

educational institutions and research foundations of its own. The most recent large research exercise on the record ran through the statistics office instead: the [Eritrea Population and Health Survey 2025](#) was completed using digital data-collection tools.

Inclusion

Access to services

More than 679,000 Eritrean refugees and asylum-seekers were known to UNHCR worldwide by December 2025, hosted mainly by Ethiopia, Sudan, Germany, Uganda, Egypt and Switzerland. In April 2026 the agency issued a [Guidance Note on Eritrea](#), replacing eligibility guidelines that had stood since 2011. Traffic the other way is negligible: Eritrea [hosts 119 refugees under UNHCR's mandate](#) (January 2026), and is [party to none of the three refugee conventions](#) and has no national law on refugee or asylum-seeker protection.

Equal access to public services scored 19.0 out of 100 in 2023, 47th of 54 African states and 0.8 points below its level ten years earlier. Entry is controlled at the door — [obtaining a SIM card requires government approval](#), and the UNDP compass places civic engagement at its lowest stage, technology not being used for interaction between citizens and government (2024). The [UN's 2024 e-government survey](#) registered no measurable central-government online service provision. The live public-facing channel that does exist is EriTel's [internet complaint hub](#), a web form for reporting connectivity and web-access faults.

The gate to what services there are is paper. The [identity card is required of everyone over 18 and needed both for a passport and to reach government services](#), while some groups, Jehovah's Witnesses and military deserters among them, are documented as refused it as a sanction (2024); the card [remained in limited circulation in November 2025](#), most citizens still holding the older hand-written version. [Rural Eritrea has no civil status officers](#), so births, deaths and marriages outside the towns are declared informally where they are declared at all (2025), and [limited access to documentation raises the risk of statelessness](#) for refugees and asylum-seekers (January 2026).

Eritrea [acceded to the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities in December 2024](#). In July 2026 the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child found that the country has [no independent children's ombudsperson able to receive and investigate complaints](#) and recommended that one be established. There are [no automatic teller machines, no debit or credit cards and no internet banking](#) (August 2024).

Digital divides

Eritrea's most recent household survey of ICT use was taken in [2002, the oldest household-survey data year of any country in the ITU's Africa subregional dataset](#) (March 2026). The Ibrahim Index put [inclusion and equality at 23.4 out of 100 in 2023](#), 51st of 54 African states and 3.7 points below its level a decade earlier.

Where connectivity is measured, the movement is upward from nothing. The [mobile communications score reached 32.6 out of 100 in 2023](#), 51st of 54 and the second most improved of that index's 96 indicators for Eritrea, the whole ten-year gain measured from a score of zero in 2014. [Internet and computers stood at 23.5 out of 100](#), 40th of 54, up 22.4 points over the same period. The ceiling on that improvement is technological: there is [no commercial 4G network in the country at all](#), and EriTel's 2G coverage sits around Asmara and the main urban corridors (2021).

What access exists is [concentrated in the towns and at national level](#): no government digital system has any sub-national participation, electricity is concentrated in the major cities, and physical infrastructure scores at the lowest stage the UNDP compass records (2024). Price closes off much of the rest — an entry-level mobile-broadband package cost [far more than the UN Broadband Commission's affordability benchmark](#) at the prices recorded in 2022.

The one funded attempt at closing a gap runs through schools: [US\\$11.82m in Global Partnership for Education system transformation funding](#) and [US\\$2.2m in system capacity funding](#), with UNICEF as grant agent, targets the zobas holding nomadic, semi-nomadic and remote rural communities that lag the national average (April 2024). Women remained a minority of the graduates at [Mai-Nefhi College of Engineering and Technology's July 2026 commencement](#).

Eritrea is named in none of the 28 regional East African digital commitments on its finance record — the East African Community and IGAD-anchored programmes for digital integration, AI research, digital skills, cross-border payments and connectivity all run past it (September 2026).

Data

National statistics

The National Statistics Office finished fieldwork on the fourth round of the Eritrea Population and Health Survey, covering 9,794 households across 405 enumeration areas at a 98.4% completion rate (May 2026), the first national survey of its kind in fifteen years and the first the office has run on digital instruments rather than paper, with UNFPA carrying half of its US\$535,000 budget (2025).

It is a sample survey and not a census. Eritrea has held no population, agricultural or economic census in the past twenty years and, before this round, no household, labour force, health, agricultural or business survey in the past ten (2023). Its last household survey of ICT use dates from 2002, the oldest such data year in the ITU's Africa subregional set, and no return has been made to the ITU's telecommunications indicators questionnaire since 2017, the longest gap of any country in that set (March 2026). On the World Bank's 2023 reading the data infrastructure pillar scores below 20 per cent, data use between 20 and 49, and data products between 50 and 69, while data services and data sources are not scored at all.

A draft National Statistical Proclamation making the office the national statistical centre had been submitted to government but not enacted (January 2007), leaving it working without a dedicated statutory mandate. Its capacity score reached 35.9 out of 100 in 2023, 39th of 54 African states and up 18.3 points over the decade, among the country's fastest-improving governance measures, on an index holding no Eritrean data for eighteen of its 96 indicators. UNECA spent two weeks in January 2026 training the office on GDP compilation under the 2008 System of National Accounts; African Development Bank financing has equipped it with servers, computers and software for a data centre of its own (2025) and pilot collection of administrative data from the finance, agriculture and education ministries (2026). Data on child labour, violence against children, child marriage and children in conflict with the law is not systematically collected, the African children's rights committee found in observations adopted in April 2026.

Open data

Eritrea scored 0.0 out of 100 for accessibility of public records in 2023, last of 54 African states and 6.3 points down over the decade, and 12.5 for disclosure of public records, 47th of 54 and unchanged across the same ten years. No freedom-of-information law has been adopted (January 2026).

Nothing is disclosed publicly about government data systems, data-sharing arrangements or interoperability work, and UNDP's Digital Development Compass places the open-government dimension at its lowest stage — closed, with no information sharing and no feedback or evaluation mechanisms (2022). Open datasets about the country are largely made elsewhere: WFP maintains subnational rainfall indicators for Eritrea on the Humanitarian Data Exchange, refreshed roughly every two weeks (July 2026).

Eritrea is party to the Samoa Agreement, whose general part [commits its signatories to using digital solutions to widen public access to information](#); domestically, a [draft Law on National Archives and Libraries](#) has been prepared with expert input from the Research and Documentation Centre and the University of Pavia (November 2025).

Use of satellite data

The most recent dry-conditions alert covering Eritrea was issued not by the Eritrean state but by IGAD's regional climate centre, whose [Climate Watch advisory of 10 August 2026](#), valid to 11 September, raised alert levels on May-to-July rainfall deficits using standardised precipitation analysis alongside satellite-derived soil-moisture and [vegetation-stress monitoring](#). Eritrea has no modern national meteorological service: at the UNCCD's sixteenth conference of the parties its delegation listed [setting one up among the country's forward strategies against drought and desertification](#) (December 2024).

Routine satellite monitoring of Eritrean territory runs from outside it. WFP computes forecast, preliminary and final rainfall indicators for Eritrean subnational units from CHIRPS satellite precipitation imagery blended with station data and short-term forecasts, published on the Humanitarian Data Exchange and refreshed roughly every two weeks (July 2026). Eurac Research took high-resolution hydrological modelling and its geodesign platform to Asmara's Toker and Mainefhi catchments across two rounds of workshops in July 2026.

The state's own capability sits in the Ministry of Agriculture, whose [Agricultural Strategic Information System Division](#), created in 2019, brings GIS and remote sensing, IT, an agricultural innovation unit and an expert system [under one division](#) and runs an agro-meteorological station network whose readings are passed to agricultural extension workers. Geospatial skills are being built in a second ministry: UNECA's training of Ministry of Land, Water and Environment staff in remote sensing and satellite land-cover classification closed in Asmara in February 2026, and Eritrea [submitted a domesticated UN Integrated Geospatial Information Framework action plan to UNECA on 6 April 2026](#). The Cadastral Office's conversion of land registration from manual to digital has not yet reached the [spatial component, leaving spatial and textual records unintegrated](#) (2020).

Most of the satellite and geospatial work bearing on Eritrea is run from outside the country, by UN agencies, the regional climate centre and a European research institute; the agriculture ministry's information division is the state's own share of it.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

United States policy toward Eritrea as at August 2026 still ran through the [sanctions imposed in November 2021 on the Eritrean Defense Force, the ruling PFDJ, the Hidri Trust and the Red Sea Trading Corporation](#), with further restrictions and individual designations standing alongside them under separate legal authorities.

China activities

No Chinese-funded or Chinese-built digital or data project was under way in Eritrea as at September 2026.

EU activities

European engagement with Eritrea's data capacity runs through institutions and heritage projects rather than through government digital programmes. The most recent of them is [Eurac Research's NBS4Water project, which ran two rounds of geodesign workshops in Asmara in July 2026](#), applying high-resolution hydrological modelling to the city's Toker and Mainefhi catchments; its money comes from Italy's Autonomous Province of Bolzano, not from Brussels.

EU funding proper has gone to the Research and Documentation Centre in Asmara, [equipped through three successive EU-funded projects, with Italy's University of Pavia as technical partner, to digitise and preserve archives, manuscripts and audiovisual material](#) as at November 2025. The same work has produced a [draft Law on National Archives and Libraries](#), prepared with expert input from the Centre, the University of Pavia and an in-country team.

The treaty frame is the [Samoa Agreement, which lists the State of Eritrea among the OACPS parties and has applied provisionally since 1 January 2024](#). What it asks of Eritrea it asks of every party: [accelerating e-governance and the digitalisation of public registries, strengthening national statistical systems, building a personal-data-protection regime overseen by an independent supervisory authority, and using digital solutions to widen public access to information](#). All four sit in the agreement's General Part, which binds the whole membership alike.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf or Emirati investment in Eritrea's data or digital infrastructure was under way as at September 2026.

India activities

No Indian government or industry involvement in Eritrea's data and digital sector was under way as at September 2026.

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